

The FSA-OWI Collection

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Farm Security Administration/Office of War Information

December 1 - W 30, 2025



*Jack Delano, 1941 –
Son of Tenant Farmer
near Greensboro, Al
35 mm nitrate negative,
FSA-OWI Collection.*

Introduction

About the FSA/OWI Black-and-White Negatives

The photographs in the *Farm Security Administration/Office of War Information* Photograph Collection form an extensive pictorial record of American life between 1935 and 1944. This U.S. government photography project was headed for most of its existence by Roy E. Stryker, who guided the effort in a succession of government agencies: the Resettlement Administration (1935-1937), the Farm Security Administration (1937-1942), and the Office of War Information (1942-1944). The collection also includes photographs acquired from other governmental and non-governmental sources, including the News Bureau at the Offices of Emergency Management (OEM), various branches of the military, and industrial corporations.

Background and Scope of the Collection

The photographs of the *Farm Security Administration - Office of War Information* Photograph Collection form an extensive pictorial record of American life between 1935 and 1944. This U.S. government photography project was headed for most of its existence by Roy E. Stryker, formerly an economics instructor at Columbia University, and employed such photographers as Walker Evans, Dorothea Lange, Russell Lee, Arthur Rothstein, Ben Shahn, Jack Delano, Marion Post Wolcott, Gordon Parks, John Vachon, and Carl Mydans. The project initially documented cash loans made to individual farmers by the Resettlement Administration and the construction of planned suburban communities. The second stage focused on the lives of sharecroppers in the South and migratory agricultural workers in the mid-western and western states. As the scope of the project expanded, the photographers turned to recording both rural and urban conditions throughout

the United States as well as mobilization efforts for World War II. The collection encompasses the images made by photographers working in Stryker's unit as it existed in a succession of government agencies: the Resettlement Administration (1935-1937), the Farm Security Administration (1937-1942), and the Office of War Information (1942-1944). The collection also includes photographs acquired from other governmental and non-governmental sources, including the News Bureau at the Offices of Emergency Management (OEM), various branches of the military, and industrial corporations. In total, the collection consists of about 175,000 black-and-white film negatives and transparencies, 1,610 color transparencies, and around 107,000 black-and-white photographic prints, most of which were made from the negatives and transparencies. The collection was transferred to the Library of Congress in 1944.



small lives growing in narrow places.



15244-F



*Jack Delano, 1940 –
Farmingham, North Carolina
Son of a tobacco tenant farmer
FSA-OWI Collection,
Library Of Congress*

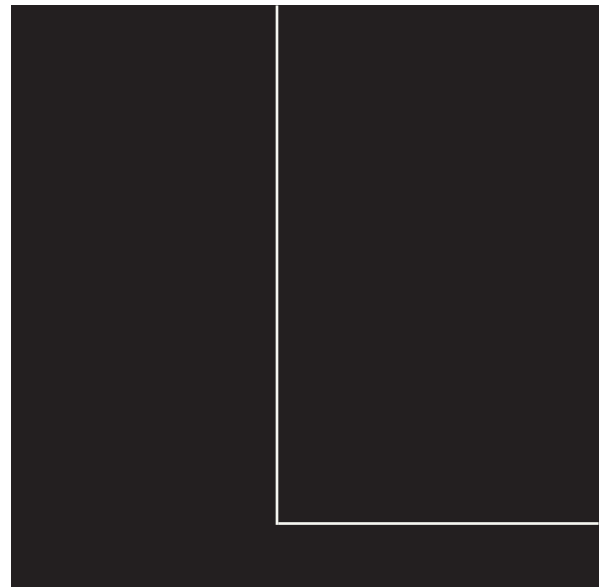
How the Photographs Were Produced

Although photographers in Roy Stryker's unit were sent out on assignments throughout the United States and Puerto Rico, the unit's main office was in Washington, D.C. The office distributed photographic equipment and film, drew up budgets, allocated travel funds, hired staff, developed, printed, and numbered most negatives, reviewed developed film, edited photographers' captions written in the field, and maintained files of negatives, prints, and captions. The main office also distributed images to newspapers, magazines, and book publishers, and supplied photographs to exhibitions.

Staff photographers were given specific subjects and/or geographic areas to cover. These field assignments often lasted several months. Before beginning their assignments, photographers read relevant reports, local newspapers, and books in order to become familiar with their subject. A basic shooting script or outline was often prepared. Photographers were encouraged to record anything that might shed additional light on the topic that they were photographing, and they received training in making personal contacts and interviewing people.

Most of the time the photographers mailed their exposed negatives to the photographic unit's lab in Washington for developing, numbering and printing. [View images of the photo lab.] In the initial years of the project Stryker was almost exclusively responsible for reviewing contact prints made from the negatives and selecting images that he considered suitable for printing. Over time, however, photographers played a greater role in picture selection. Rejected images were classified as "killed." In earlier phases

of the project a hole was sometimes punched through the "killed" negatives; later, this practice was abandoned. The rejected images are usually near duplicates and alternate views of a printed negative. (For insight on FSA selection of images to be printed, see: Fleischhauer, Carl. "Selecting Photographs for the FSA/OWI Print File: a Photo-Assignment Case Study: John Vachon's Documentation of the Roanoke Farms Resettlement Project, Halifax County, North Carolina, April 1938" (25 June 2020). After Stryker reviewed and selected images, the negatives and contact prints (or "first prints") were returned to the photographers for captioning. The resulting captions were edited at the photographic unit's headquarters. The selected images were then printed and mounted, the captions were applied to the photo mounts, and the photographs were filed in the photographic unit's file.



small shoulders carrying more than childhood.

Exhibition

As you move through this exhibition catalog, the photographs ask you to slow down and see the world through their eyes. They remind us that children often carry the story of a generation, quietly, instinctively, and without the vocabulary adults use to frame struggle. In these images, their presence becomes the anchor of the collection: a testament to endurance, family, and the ways young people navigate and embody history without ever knowing they are doing so.



“Staff photographers were given specific subjects and/or geographic areas to cover. These field assignments often lasted several months.”



*Pomp Hall family,
Creek County, Oklahoma.
Jack Delano, 1940 –
FSA–OWI Collection,
Library Of Congress*







Pomp Hall family,
Creek County, Oklahoma.
Jack Delano, 1940 –
FSA-OWI Collection,
Library Of Congress



*Pomp Hall family,
Creek County, Oklahoma.
Jack Delano, 1940 –
FSA–OWI Collection,
Library Of Congress*





*Pomp Hall family,
Creek County, Oklahoma.
Jack Delano, 1940 –
FSA–OWI Collection,
Library Of Congress*

*Children In Puerto Rico, 1942 –
Photographs by Jack Delano, FSA-OWI
Collection, Library Of Congress. Families in
Yauco and Utuado slum areas.*

48096-E



48097-E



48099-E



*Children In Puerto Rico, 1942 –
Photographs by Jack Delano, FSA-OWI
Collection, Library Of Congress. Families in
Yauco and Utuado slum areas.*





*Jack Delano, 1941 –
Puerto Rico, FSA Borrowers Family
FSA-OWI Collection,
Library Of Congress*

Checklist

1. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to:*

San Juan, Puerto Rico. Children in La Perla, the slum area

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1941 Dec.*

Medium: *1 negative : nitrate ; 2 1/4 x 2 1/4 inches or smaller.*

2. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to: San German (vicinity).*

Farm laborer's family

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer in the hills*

Date Created/Published: *1942 Jan.*

Medium: *1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.*

3. Title: *Utuado, Puerto Rico. In the slum area*

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1942 Jan.*

Medium: *1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.*

4. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to:*

Rio Piedras (vicinity), Puerto Rico. Wife and

children of a FSA (Farm Security Administration) borrower

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1941 Dec.*

Medium: *1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.*

5. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to:*

Rio Piedras (vicinity), Puerto Rico. Wife and

children of a FSA (Farm Security Administration) borrower

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1941 Dec.*

Medium: *1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.*

6. Title: *Children in the workers' quarter of Puerto de Tierra.*

Note the water of the tidalswamp under the houses and "sidewalk."

San Juan, Puerto Rico

Creator(s): *Roskam, Edwin, 1903-1985, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1937 Dec.*

Medium: *1 negative : nitrate ; 2 1/4 x 2 1/4 inches or smaller.*

7. Title: *Yauco, Puerto Rico. Children in the slum areas*

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1942 Jan.*

Medium: *1 negative : nitrate ; 35 mm.*

8. Title: *Children in the workers' quarter of Puerto de Tierra.*

San Juan, Puerto Rico

Creator(s): *Roskam, Edwin, 1903-1985, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1938 Jan.*

Medium: *1 negative : nitrate ; 2 1/4 x 2 1/4 inches or smaller.*

9. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to: San Juan, Puerto Rico.*

In the huge slum area known as "El Fangitto"

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1942 Jan.*

Medium: *1 negative : nitrate ; 2 1/4 x 2 1/4 inches or smaller.*

10. Title: *Utuado, Puerto Rico. Children in the slum area*

Creator(s): *Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer*

Date Created/Published: *1942 Jan.*

Medium: *1 negative : nitrate ; 2 1/4 x 2 1/4 inches or smaller*

11. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to: Daughter of Pomp Hall, Negro tenant farmer, feeding corn to her three chickens which were her 4-H Club project, Creek County, Oklahoma.*

See general caption number 23 Creator(s): Lee, Russell, 1903-1986, photographer

Date Created/Published: [1940 Feb.]

Medium: 1 negative : safety ; 35 mm

12. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to:*

Son of Pomp Hall, Negro tenant farmer, eating

black walnuts which were grown on their farm in Creek County,

Oklahoma. See general caption number 23 Creator(s): Lee, Russell, 1903-1986, photographer

Date Created/Published: [1940 Feb.]

Medium: 1 negative : nitrate ; 35 mm.

13. Title: *Negro child, son of a tobacco*

tenant farmer near Farmingham, North Carolina

Creator(s): Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer

Date Created/Published: 1940 May.

Medium: 1 negative : nitrate ; 35 mm.

14 .Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to:*

Son of Negro tenant farmer on a farm near Greensboro, Alabama

Creator(s): Delano, Jack, 1914-1997, photographer

Date Created/Published: [1941 May]

Medium: 1 negative : nitrate ; 35 mm.

15. Title: *Children of Pomp Hall, Negro tenant farmer, eating.*

Creek County, Oklahoma. See general caption number 23

Creator(s): Lee, Russell, 1903-1986, photographer

Date Created/Published: 1940 Feb.

Medium: 1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.

16. Title: *Son of Pomp Hall, Negro tenant farmer, coming through doorway in his house.*

Creek County, Oklahoma. See general caption number 23

Creator(s): Lee, Russell, 1903-1986, photographer

Date Created/Published: 1940 Feb.

Medium: 1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.

17. Title: *Untitled photo, possibly related to:*

Son of Pomp Hall, Negro tenant farmer, coming through doorway in his house. Creek County, Oklahoma.

See general caption number 23

Creator(s): Lee, Russell, 1903-1986, photographer

Date Created/Published: 1940 Feb.

Medium: 1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.

18. Title: *Two daughters of Pomp Hall, Negro tenant farmer, making patchwork cushions for chairs.*

Creek County, Oklahoma. See general caption number 23

Creator(s): Lee, Russell, 1903-1986, photographer

Date Created/Published: 1940 Feb.

Medium: 1 negative : safety ; 3 1/4 x 4 1/4 inches or smaller.

19. Title: *Detail of clothes of children of Negro sharecropper who will be resettled on Transylvania Project, Louisiana.*

Note the cloth shoelaces Creator(s): Lee, Russell, 1903-1986, photographer

Date Created/Published: 1939 Jan.

Medium: 1 negative : nitrate ; 35 mm.

